

CONTACT

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in linkedin.com/in/sabaza

⊕ Available Worldwide

▣ Citizenship: Dutch

CORE CAPABILITIES

› Flagship summit & forum production

› Leading regional & global event teams

› End-to-end operations & delivery

› Heads-of-state & VVIP protocol

› Government, policy & investor audiences

› Agency building & team leadership (140+)

› Operational playbooks & vendor frameworks

› Multi-market, cross-cultural delivery

LANGUAGES

Arabic	**Native**
English	**Native**
French	**Excellent**
Spanish	**Excellent**
Dutch	**Working**
Polish	**Working**
Portuguese	**Basic**
Italian	**Basic**
Romanian	**Basic**

INTERESTS

› Basketball coach; former national youth player.

› Travelled across 100+ countries.

› Active use of AI in event production and planning.

Sherif Abaza

Senior Events Director & Producer · 20+ Years · Global Summits, Forums & Live Experiences

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◆ Profile

Senior events director and producer with 20+ years building and leading the regional and global teams that deliver the world's highest-stakes live experiences. Founded and scaled a 140-person events agency in Dubai delivering 800+ events, directed three consecutive COP climate summits, and produced the inaugural Dubai International Film Festival. My work sits where creative ambition meets operational reality — heads-of-state protocol, investor and policy audiences, multi-country production, and the playbooks that hold it all together under pressure.

I own the full event lifecycle: concept and creative direction, production and operations, budget and P&L, stakeholder and client management, and post-event measurement. I have built the teams, supplier networks, and delivery infrastructure that let distributed regional and global operations run to a single standard. Nine languages, delivery across 80+ countries, audiences from government ministers to tens of thousands of consumers.

◆ Professional Experience

Abaza Business Services · Global

Founder & Managing Director 2019 – Present

- End-to-end event delivery and production for **COP27 (Egypt)**, **COP28 (UAE)**, and **COP29 (Azerbaijan)** — leading multinational teams, on-site operations, and stakeholder programming for the world's largest mixed-audience summits.
- Engaged as production and delivery partner by leading global experiential agencies — **Jack Morton**, **Shelton Fleming**, and **Impact XM** — providing on-the-ground regional team leadership, production management, and operational delivery for their international and Middle East programmes.
- Strategic advisor on event design, production and stakeholder management for government and corporate clients navigating complex, high-protocol audience environments.
- NBA market launch support: developed event programme strategy for European and African market-entry initiatives with senior league stakeholders.

Sphere Events and Communication · Dubai, UAE

Founder & Managing Director 2008 – 2018

- Built from a sole operator to a **140-person multinational events agency**; revenues exceeding **USD 8 million** annually across 800+ summit, conference, brand activation, and public-experience programmes.
- Owned agency P&L and led regional teams across production, design, logistics, client servicing and talent — structured for performance under high-pressure, multi-event delivery.
- Developed and managed long-term client relationships with global corporations including **Siemens, Porsche, Cartier, Ericsson, and Emaar** — from brief through to delivered experience.
- Produced landmark public events including **Street Nights**, **Dubai Chocolate Festival**, and **Marina Music Festival** — audiences of tens of thousands, full production ownership throughout.
- Built the agency's operational playbooks, QA systems, and supplier frameworks — the infrastructure that made 800+ events possible without sacrificing quality.

Withlocals B.V. · Eindhoven, Netherlands

Chief Community Officer 2022 – 2026

Chief Growth Officer 2018 – 2022

- Built and scaled a global community and experience organisation across **80+ countries, 300+ cities** — designing and operating experiential touchpoints at scale.
- Led pivot to virtual experiences during COVID: activated the global network to deliver **70+ corporate clients** in under 90 days, zero ad budget.
- Owned the B2B experience partnership framework: deal structure, client onboarding, and multi-year retention across enterprise accounts.

ASDAA Burson-Marsteller · Dubai, UAE

Senior Account Manager 2004 – 2006

- Key role producing the **inaugural Dubai International Film Festival** — a flagship event that positioned Dubai as an international cultural destination from day one.
- Brand experience campaigns for Siemens, Adidas, and Hilton across the Middle East — early foundation in production and stakeholder alignment.

FrontFlip (me360) · Kansas City, USA / MENA

CEO, Middle East & North Africa 2010 – 2015

- Co-led regional operations for a mobile loyalty startup; raised **USD 1.8M** in early-stage funding.
- Built and managed a 35-person cross-functional team across 6+ MENA markets — product, partnerships, and field operations.

Sundance Events · Dubai, UAE

Business Development & Operations Manager 2006 – 2008

- Events business development and operational delivery for corporate and government clients across the UAE.
- Built client relationships and supplier networks that laid the foundation for founding Sphere Events.

Leadership & Development

AIESEC International

Various Leadership Roles 1999 – 2004

- Progressive leadership positions including Local Committee President and National Support Team roles.
- Led cross-cultural teams and international exchange programmes — the earliest foundation of a career built on cross-cultural trust and programme design.

Education

Bachelor of Computer Engineering

Arab Academy for Science, Technology and Maritime Transport · Alexandria, Egypt